



Subject Vision and Intent: Phonics and Early Reading

Our Vision

At King's Cross Academy, we believe that every child can become a reader. Learning to read is one of the most important things children will learn at school: it gives them access to the wider curriculum, enables increasing independence and opens the door to a lifetime of stories, knowledge and ideas.

Our ambition is for children to develop both the knowledge they need to read successfully and a genuine love of reading. Through high-quality phonics teaching, carefully matched books and a language-rich reading environment, we want children to experience success from the beginning and develop confidence in themselves as readers.

We want children to leave the early stages of their education able to decode accurately, read with increasing fluency and understand and enjoy what they read. At the same time, we want them to discover the pleasure of books: listening to stories, talking about characters and ideas, encountering new vocabulary and developing their own preferences as readers.

Our approach reflects our Academy vision, *Love Learning Together*. Learning to read requires courage, practice and endurance, and we celebrate the small steps through which children become increasingly independent. Above all, we want every child to know that reading is for them.

Our Intent

Our approach to Phonics and Early Reading is ambitious, inclusive, systematic and carefully sequenced. We use Little Wandle Letters and Sounds Revised from Nursery onwards, providing a consistent journey through the foundations of phonics and into systematic teaching of the alphabetic code.

In Nursery, children follow the Little Wandle Foundations programme. Through carefully planned experiences with sounds, language, stories, songs and rhymes, children develop the foundations upon which successful phonics and reading are built. They learn to listen carefully, discriminate between sounds, develop phonological awareness and explore the sounds within spoken language. These experiences deliberately prepare children for the systematic phonics teaching that follows.

From Reception, children are systematically taught the relationship between phonemes and graphemes. They learn to recognise graphemes, blend sounds to read words and segment spoken words to support spelling. New learning is carefully sequenced and previously taught knowledge is regularly revisited so that children develop increasingly secure and automatic recall.

Daily phonics teaching provides explicit instruction and frequent opportunities for practice. Children are expected to participate actively, say sounds, read words and apply what they know, enabling teachers to identify quickly where additional teaching or practice may be required.

Children read books that are closely matched to the phonics knowledge they have been taught. This enables them to apply their developing knowledge successfully rather than relying upon guessing from pictures or context. Repeated reading develops accuracy, fluency, confidence and comprehension, helping children move progressively from decoding individual words towards reading increasingly automatically and with expression.

As children's decoding becomes more secure, increasing attention is given to fluency. Children develop the accuracy, automaticity, appropriate pace and expression that allow them to focus less upon the mechanics of decoding and more upon understanding what they read.

Reading Beyond Phonics

Learning to read involves more than learning to decode. Alongside phonics, children experience a rich reading curriculum from the very beginning. Adults read high-quality stories, poems, rhymes and non-fiction aloud so that children's experience of literature is never limited by what they can currently decode independently.

Through these texts, children encounter ambitious vocabulary, explore characters and ideas, make predictions, ask and answer questions and talk about what they have heard and read. These experiences develop children's language and comprehension while helping them discover the enjoyment that comes from sharing books.

We want children to understand the difference between the books they are learning to read for themselves and the rich, ambitious literature they can experience through being read to. Both are essential in developing successful readers.

Every Child

Learning to read is an entitlement for every child, and we have high expectations for all pupils.

Assessment is used precisely to identify what children know and where further teaching is required. Children who are at risk of falling behind are identified quickly and receive additional practice and targeted teaching that closely matches the content of the Little Wandle programme.

Our ambition is for children to keep up rather than have to catch up. Additional support therefore begins as soon as a need is identified, with regular opportunities to practise the specific knowledge children need to become increasingly secure and fluent.

Children with SEND, children who are disadvantaged and children who are developing English as an additional language are supported to access the same systematic approach. Teaching is adapted through modelling, repetition, additional practice, visual cues and carefully targeted support so that barriers are reduced without lowering expectations.

We recognise that children's experiences of books and reading beyond school vary. At KCA, every child therefore has access to high-quality books, expert teaching and regular opportunities to hear, discuss, practise and enjoy reading.

Strong relationships with families are also important. We support parents and carers to understand how children are taught to read at KCA and how they can help at home, particularly by practising with appropriately matched books and sharing and enjoying a wide range of literature together.

Developing a Reading Identity

Learning the mechanics of reading is only the beginning. Our wider ambition is for children to begin to see themselves as readers.

Children are surrounded by books and stories and have regular opportunities to listen to adults reading with enthusiasm, talk about books, revisit favourites and discover new authors, characters and ideas. Adults model the pleasure that can come from reading and help children develop their own interests and preferences.

As children become increasingly fluent, the balance progressively shifts from learning how to read towards reading to learn and reading for pleasure. The secure foundations established through early reading enable children to access increasingly sophisticated texts and participate fully in the wider curriculum.

By the end of Key Stage 1, our aim is for children to have secured the phonics knowledge necessary to decode accurately and increasingly automatically, to read with growing fluency and comprehension, and to possess the confidence to approach unfamiliar texts independently.

Above all, we want children to emerge from their early reading journey as confident, fluent and enthusiastic readers who have experienced the success and pleasure of reading and are ready to use it to learn, imagine and explore throughout the rest of their education.